Table7.3 Important Conservation Sites In India (Dec 2016)

Reserves/Conservation Sites	Numbers	Total Area in Sqkm.
Tiger Reserves	50	71027
Elephant Reserves	32	69583
Biosphere Reserves	18	87492
RAMSAR Wetland Sites	26	12119
Natural World Heritage Sites	07	11756
Important Coastal and Marine Biodiversity Areas	107	10773
Marine Protected Areas	131	9801
Potential/ Important Bird Areas	563	–

Source: ENVIS Centre on Wildlife & Protected Areas (http://www.wiienvis.nic.in/Database/ConservationAreas_844.aspx)

reserves in 1973 the number has now grown to fifty (50) in 2016. Table 7.3. gives a list of conservation sites and their numbers in India.

9. **Role of communities:** Communities are playing a vital role in the conservation and protection of wildlife in India, example:

- **Sariska Tiger Reserve:** In Sariska tiger reserve Rajasthan villagers have fought against mining by citing the wildlife protection act. In many areas, villagers themselves are protecting habitats and explicitly rejecting government involvement.
- **Bhairodev Dakav Sonchuri:** The inhabitants of five villages in the Alwar district of Rajasthan have declared 1200 hectares of forests as the Bhairodev Dakav Sonchuri declaring their own set of rules and regulation which do not allow hunting, and are protecting the wildlife against any outside encroachments.
- **Bishnoi villages:** In and around Bishnoi villages in Rajasthan, herds of blackbuck, nilgai and peacocks can be seen as an integral part of the community and nobody harms them.

Activity

Identify community conserved areas in Tamil Nadu and prepare a poster.

Highlight:

In 1798, in a small village called **Vedanthangal** near **Chennai,** the British soldiers shot some storks in the local wetland. The villagers stormed the Collector's office and made him issue an order not to harm the nesting birds. This took place long before the concept of conservation of biosphere entered our thoughts. India has experienced many such incidents only some of which have been recorded.

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